

Blackstone, end to end. Everything you need before 18:00.

*How the world's largest alternative asset manager is built,
how it earns, who runs it, what it is betting on right now —
and the questions worth asking about all of it.*

\$1.35tn

Total assets under management, Q2 2026 — a firm record

4

Reporting segments, from Real Estate to Multi-Asset

\$555bn

Perpetual capital — money that never has to be given back

~5,300

Employees worldwide; 650+ of them in London

Prepared for	Janak Chohan
Occasion	Blackstone SEO Networking Evening
Venue	40 Berkeley Square, London W1J 5AL
Date	Wednesday 2 September 2026, 18:00–20:00
Focus	Business structure, economics, client-facing franchise
Basis	Public filings, earnings calls and press reporting to 2 Sept 2026

What is in here, and how to use it

Read Parts 0–3 if you read nothing else: they take you from zero knowledge to being able to follow any conversation in the room. Part 5 is written for the roles you care about. Part 11 is the thing to skim in the taxi.

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ONE CAVEAT, STATED UP FRONT

You asked for "insider information." Everything in this report is drawn from public sources — SEC filings, quarterly earnings calls, press releases and mainstream financial press. That is not a limitation in practice: almost nobody at a networking evening expects you to know anything, so knowing what was said on the Q2 2026 earnings call already puts you well ahead. What it does mean is that you should never *claim* inside knowledge. The credible move is the opposite: cite the public record precisely and ask the person in front of you for the colour that isn't in it.

Blackstone in ninety seconds

Six paragraphs that will let you hold a conversation. Everything after this is depth on one of these six points.

1. What it is

Blackstone is the world's largest **alternative asset manager**. It does not primarily invest its own money. It raises money from pension funds, sovereign wealth funds, insurance companies and — increasingly — wealthy individuals, puts that money into things that are not publicly listed stocks and bonds (buildings, private companies, private loans, infrastructure), and charges fees for doing so. As at 30 June 2026 it manages **\$1.35 trillion**.

2. How it is organised

Four reporting segments: **Real Estate** (\$314bn), **Private Equity** (\$454bn), **Credit & Insurance** (\$469bn) and **Multi-Asset Investing** (\$109bn). Real Estate is the historic crown jewel; Credit & Insurance is now the biggest and the growth engine; Private Equity is the highest-profile. A single central spine — one capital-raising organisation, one legal function, one technology group — serves all four. That "one firm" model is the thing Blackstone people are proudest of.

3. How it earns

Two ways. **Management fees** — roughly 1–1.5% a year on capital, charged whether markets go up or down. And **performance fees** ("carried interest") — typically 20% of the profit above a hurdle, which is lumpy and cyclical. The firm has spent fifteen years deliberately making the first stream bigger and more predictable relative to the second. Watch the acronym **FRE** (Fee-Related Earnings) — it is the number the market pays for.

4. What it is betting on right now

AI infrastructure. Blackstone is the largest data centre owner in the world and, by its own description, "one of the largest private capital providers in the AI ecosystem." Its data centre platform is worth roughly **\$185 billion**, up from \$130bn at the start of 2026. In 2026 alone it launched a data-centre REIT (BXDC), a neocloud venture with Google, an enterprise AI venture with Anthropic, and a **\$35 billion** financing platform with Broadcom — the largest private credit investment ever made.

5. What is hurting

Private credit wobbled badly in early 2026. Two US bankruptcies (First Brands, Tricolor) triggered a panic; investors in semi-liquid credit funds rushed for the exit; Blackstone's flagship BCRED fund faced a record **7.9% redemption request** and had to gate withdrawals. Senior executives put **\$150 million** of their own money in to help meet redemptions. The alternative managers' shares fell roughly 30%. By Q2 the pressure was easing — but this is the live issue in the industry.

6. Where it is going

Two structural pushes. **Insurance** — managing money for life insurers is now a \$290bn business and Blackstone runs the largest third-party platform in the sector. And **individual investors** — private wealth AUM is a record \$324bn, and the next frontier is the US 401(k) retirement market, which a 2025 executive order has begun to open up. Both are attempts to find capital that behaves like permanent capital.

THE SINGLE MOST USEFUL SENTENCE TO HAVE READY

"The thing that strikes me about Blackstone is that it is really two businesses in one: an investing business that has to be brilliant at buying assets, and a capital-raising business that has to be brilliant at keeping money. The second one is the part that has actually changed most in the last five years — perpetual capital going from a niche to \$555 billion." — true, non-obvious, and it opens directly onto the client-facing side you care about.

Foundations

The assumptions the rest of this report rests on. If you already know what a limited partner is, skim to §0.5 — but the vocabulary section is the one that stops you being caught out.

0.1 What Blackstone actually is

Start with what it is *not*. Blackstone is not a bank: it does not take deposits and its business is not making loans off its own balance sheet. It is not a hedge fund in the classic sense: it does not mainly trade liquid securities. And it is not, despite the shorthand, "a private equity firm" any more — private equity is now barely a third of what it does.

Blackstone is an **asset manager**. Its product is a promise: give us your money for a defined period, and we will invest it in assets you cannot easily buy yourself, and generate a return you could not generate on your own. In exchange, we take a fee for managing it and a share of the profit if we do well.

The word "alternative" simply means *not publicly traded stocks and bonds*. Real estate. Companies bought outright. Loans made privately to businesses rather than through the bond market. Infrastructure — data centres, pipelines, energy. Hedge fund strategies. That is the whole of the definition, and it is worth saying plainly because the industry rarely does.

THE MENTAL MODEL THAT UNLOCKS EVERYTHING

Blackstone is best understood as a **machine for converting other people's capital into fee income**. Every strategic decision the firm has made in twenty years — going public, building credit, buying into insurance, courting individual investors, creating funds that never expire — is an attempt to make that fee income *larger, more durable and more predictable*. Hold that idea and the rest of the report explains itself.

0.2 The GP / LP bargain

Almost all of Blackstone's business runs through a structure that has barely changed since the 1980s. Investors — called **Limited Partners**, or LPs — commit money to a fund. Blackstone acts as the **General Partner**, or GP: it makes every investment decision, and it is the one on the hook operationally. LPs are passive by design; that is what "limited" means. They get economics and information rights, not control.

Blackstone also puts its own money in alongside — typically 1–3% of a fund — so that the firm and its employees lose money when the LPs do. That alignment is a genuine feature and it is the standard answer to "how do we know you care?"

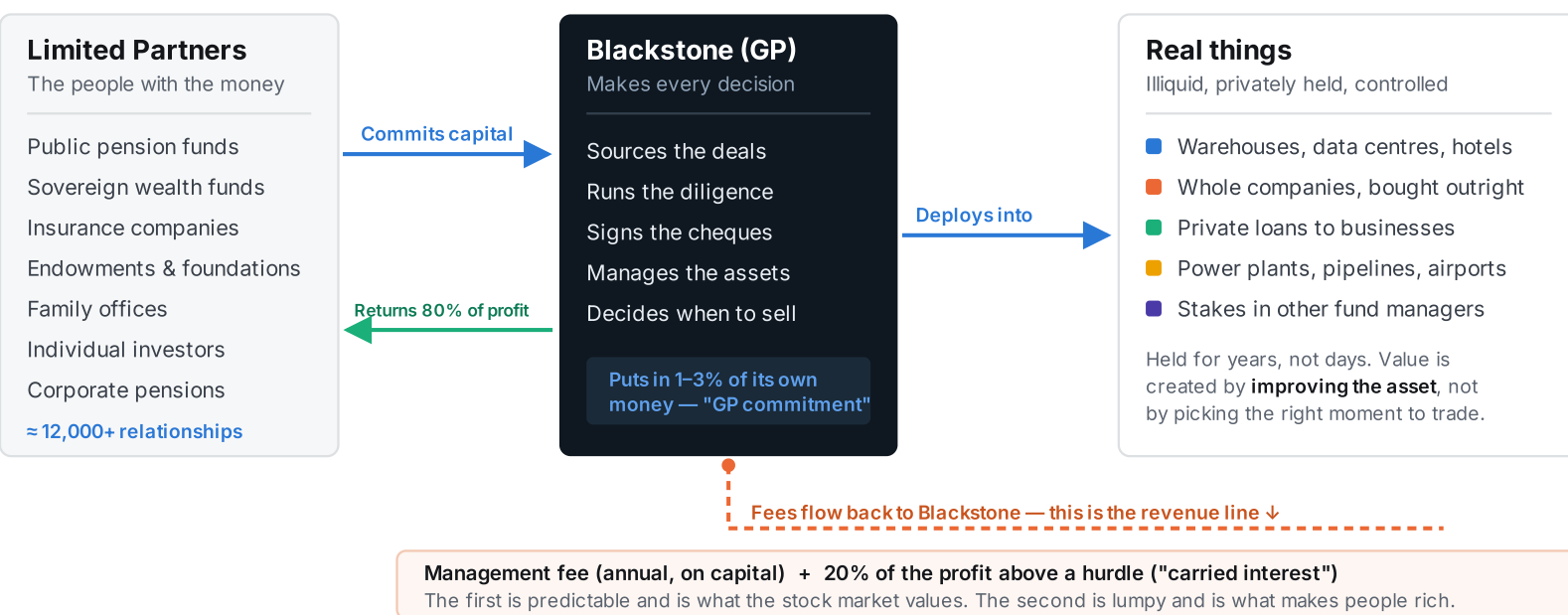


Figure 0.1 — The core structure. Every one of Blackstone's ~250 investment vehicles is a variation on this. When someone says "we're raising Fund X," they mean they are signing new LPs into a new version of the box in the middle.

0.3 The fund lifecycle, and why patience is structural

A traditional Blackstone fund — a "drawdown" or "closed-end" fund — has a life of about ten to twelve years, and it moves through phases that determine what everyone in the building is doing at any given moment.



Figure 0.2 — The lifecycle of a closed-end fund. The commercial consequence: because a fund takes a decade to pay out, Blackstone must always be raising the next one. A firm this size has funds in every phase simultaneously — which is exactly why the client-facing organisation is permanent rather than campaign-based.

WHY THIS MATTERS FOR THE ROLES YOU ARE INTERESTED IN

Because of the J-curve, an investor relations or client solutions professional spends much of their life explaining *why a fund that looks bad is fine*. Being able to hold a client's confidence through years 2–5 of a fund is the actual skill. That is a much better thing to say you find interesting than "I like talking to people."

0.4 How the fees really work

"Two and twenty" is the shorthand: a 2% annual management fee and 20% of profits. Blackstone's real numbers are lower and more varied — closer to 1.0–1.5% on average across the firm, because credit and core-plus real estate strategies carry thinner fees than flagship buyout funds — but the shape is right.

Where a pound of fund profit goes

Illustrative "European" waterfall — the structure used by most Blackstone drawdown funds

STEP 1	Return of capital — LPs get every pound they put in, back first	100% to LP
STEP 2	Preferred return ("hurdle") — usually 8% a year, compounding	100% to LP · Blackstone earns nothing until this is cleared
STEP 3	GP catch-up	100% to GP, until the GP has 20% of total profit
STEP 4	Everything thereafter is split	80% LP / 20% GP — this 20% is the "carried interest"

And the clawback: if a fund pays carry early on winners and then loses money on later deals, Blackstone must give it back.
This is why the balance-sheet line "net accrued performance revenue" (\$7.5bn at Q2 2026) is an *estimate of carry not yet locked in*, not cash in the bank.

Figure 0.3 — The distribution waterfall. The order matters enormously and is a favourite technical question. The headline: LPs get their money and an 8% return before Blackstone sees a penny of profit share. Management fees, by contrast, are paid throughout, regardless of performance.

The vocabulary you cannot fumble

Eight terms do almost all the work. Misusing any of them marks you instantly; using them precisely marks you just as fast, in the other direction.

0.5 The AUM ladder — three numbers, not one

"Assets under management" is the headline, but it is the *least* useful of the three AUM figures Blackstone reports, because a great deal of it is not currently earning a fee. Understanding the ladder below is genuinely differentiating.

Total AUM · \$1.35 trillion

Everything Blackstone manages or has been promised, at fair value plus undrawn commitments

Fee-Earning AUM · \$961.6 billion

The part actually paying a management fee today. **This is the number that drives revenue.**

Perpetual capital · \$555.6bn

Capital with no end date — the strategic prize

The ~\$390bn gap

Mostly "dry powder" — money committed by investors but not yet invested, plus assets in funds that have stopped charging fees.

\$228.1bn of dry powder is stored future revenue: when it is deployed, fees switch on.

The line that will impress anyone

"Total AUM is a vanity number — fee-earning AUM is the revenue number, and perpetual capital is the durability number. The interesting thing is that perpetual capital is growing at 15% while total AUM grows at 11%."

Figure 0.4 — The three AUM numbers, Q2 2026. Roughly 41% of everything Blackstone manages is now perpetual. Ten years ago that share was a small fraction of the total.

0.6 The glossary that matters

Dry powder

Money investors have committed but Blackstone has not yet spent. **\$228.1bn** at Q2 2026. It is an asset, not an embarrassment: it is optionality in a dislocation, and it is future fee revenue.

Perpetual capital

Vehicles with no fixed end date — BREIT, BCRED, BXPE, insurance mandates. Investors can usually redeem periodically within limits, but Blackstone never has to wind the vehicle up and re-raise it. **\$555.6bn.**

Fee-Related Earnings (FRE)

Management fees plus fee-related performance revenues, minus the costs of running the business. The recurring, predictable profit. **\$1.8bn in Q2 2026, +22% year on year, at a 58.6% margin.** This is the number analysts capitalise.

Distributable Earnings (DE)

FRE plus realised performance revenues and realised principal investment income. The cash actually available to pay shareholders. **\$2.0bn in Q2 2026, +26%.** Blackstone pays out essentially all of it as dividends.

Net accrued performance revenue

Carried interest that has been earned on paper but not yet received in cash — a store of future earnings that can still evaporate. **\$7.5bn, or about \$6.00 a share,** the highest in four years.

Deployment vs realisations

Money going out into new investments (\$34.2bn in Q2) versus money coming back from exits (\$31.8bn in Q2; \$144.5bn over the last twelve months). Realisations drive carried interest — and therefore drive whether the year is a good one.

Inflows

New money raised. **\$68.3bn in Q2 2026; roughly \$260bn over twelve months.** This is the direct scoreboard for the client-facing organisation.

Semi-liquid / non-traded vehicle

A perpetual fund sold to individuals that offers *limited* monthly or quarterly liquidity — typically capped at 5% of net asset value per quarter. The cap is a feature that prevents forced selling. When redemption requests exceed it, the fund "gates" and fills requests pro rata. This is exactly what happened to BCRED in early 2026.

THE THREE MISTAKES THAT WILL GIVE YOU AWAY

- Calling Blackstone "BlackRock." They are different firms, they are not related, and the confusion is a well-worn irritation. (BlackRock was in fact spun out of Blackstone in 1994 — a good fact, a terrible mix-up.)
- Saying "Blackstone's private equity arm" as though that is the whole firm. Private equity is 34% of AUM and Credit & Insurance is larger.
- Treating dry powder as idle cash sitting in Blackstone's bank account. It is undrawn *commitments* from investors — Blackstone does not hold it.

How a \$400,000 boutique became a \$1.35 trillion machine

History is not decoration here. Four decisions made between 1985 and 2021 explain almost everything about how Blackstone behaves today — including why it is so obsessive about not losing money, and why it is so aggressive about fee durability.



Figure 1.1 — Four decades in one column. The through-line: every crisis Blackstone survived became a new business line. The S&L collapse created the real estate franchise; the 2008 crisis created the credit franchise; the 2022 rate shock created the insurance and private wealth push.

1.1 The four decisions that still shape behaviour

DECISION 1 · ADVISORY BEFORE CAPITAL

Because Blackstone began as an advisory firm, its founding culture was relationship-led rather than trading-led. It sold trust before it sold returns. That inheritance is still visible in how heavily the firm invests in client coverage — and it is a direct line to the roles you are interested in.

DECISION 2 · DOWNSIDE FIRST

Schwarzman has said for decades that the firm's job is not losing money. Investment committee discussion begins with what can go wrong, and any partner can raise an objection regardless of seniority. Blackstone's marketing point is that it has never had a fund lose LP capital in its flagship strategies — a claim to state carefully, but the *philosophy* is real and quotable.

DECISION 3 · GO PUBLIC, THEN BEHAVE LIKE IT

The 2007 IPO changed the objective function. A private partnership optimises for carried interest; a listed company optimises for recurring, forecastable earnings. Almost everything since — credit, insurance, perpetual vehicles, retail — is a rational response to being a public company that is valued on FRE.

DECISION 4 · BUILD THE BRAND AS THE MOAT

Jon Gray attributes today's fundraising momentum to "the strength of the brand we've built." In a business where the product is a promise about the future, brand is not marketing — it is the thing that lets Blackstone raise \$260bn in twelve months while smaller managers struggle to close a fund at all.

The business structure

Four investing segments sitting on one shared spine. The segments compete for nothing and share almost everything — which is the entire point of the design.

2.1 The map

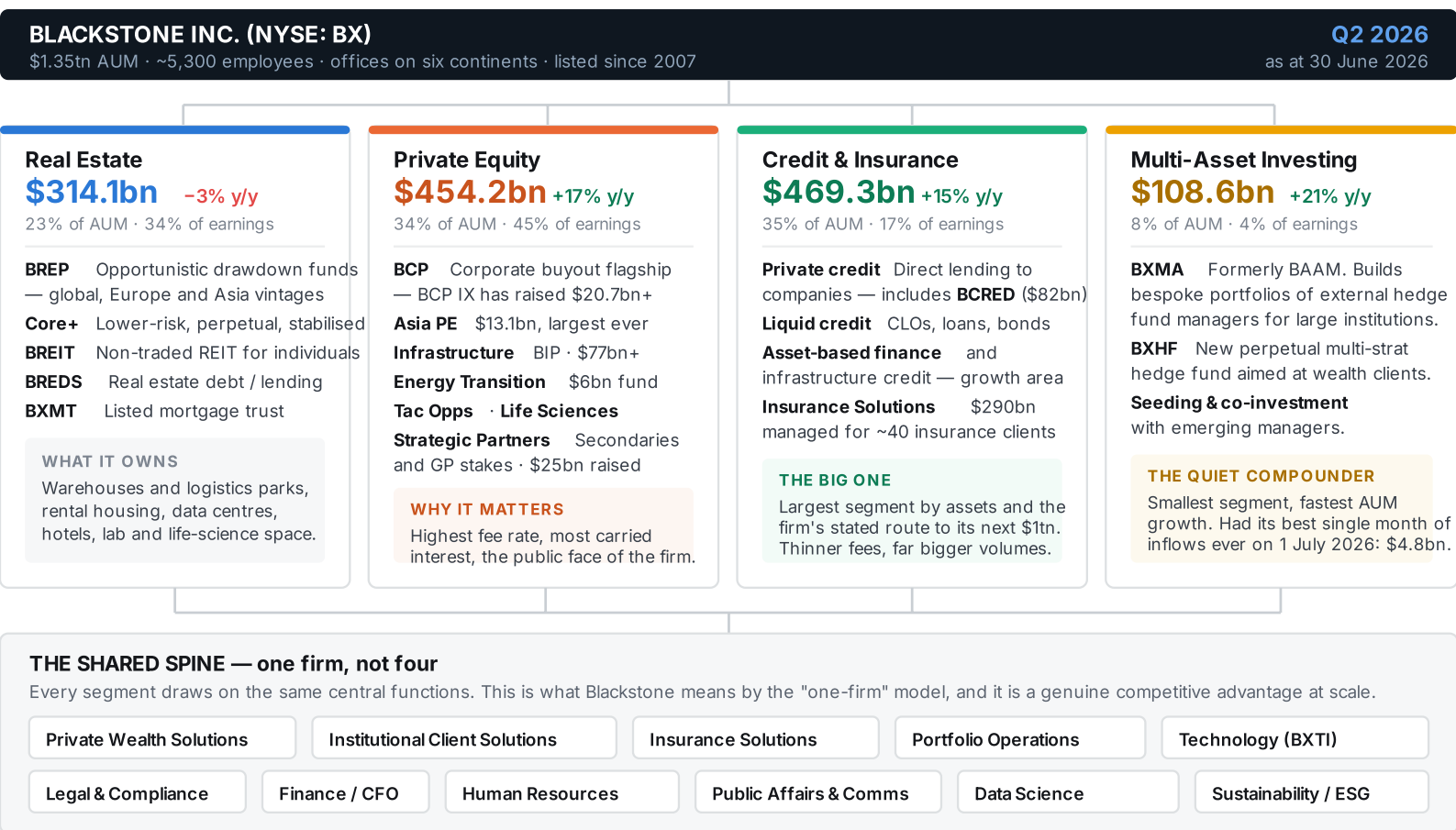


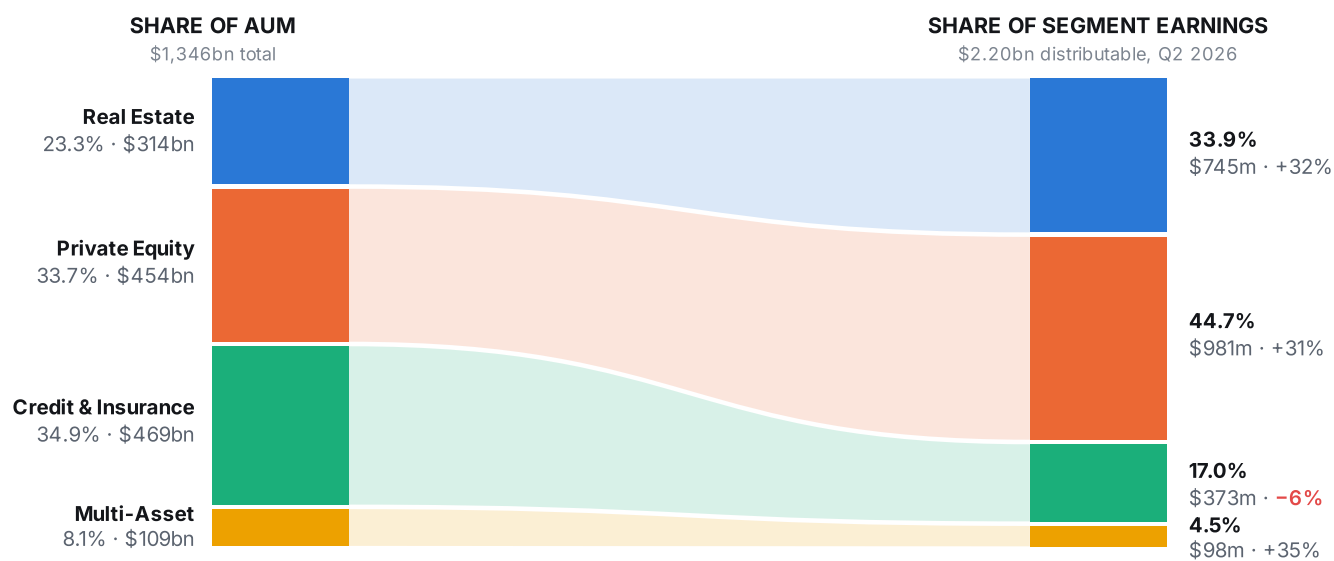
Figure 2.1 — Blackstone on one page. Segment AUM and growth from the Q2 2026 results; "share of segment earnings" is each segment's share of the \$2.2bn of total segment distributable earnings in the quarter. Note that Strategic Partners (secondaries and GP stakes) is reported inside the Private Equity segment, not Multi-Asset.

Which part actually matters most?

Depends entirely on which question you are asking. Size, profit and momentum give three different answers — and knowing that they differ is the point.

2.2 Size is not the same as earnings

This is the single most useful structural insight in the report. Credit & Insurance is Blackstone's *largest* segment by assets — and its *third* largest contributor to earnings. Private Equity is the reverse. The reason is fee rates: a private credit mandate for an insurance company might earn 30–50 basis points; a flagship buyout fund earns 1.5% plus carry. Blackstone is deliberately trading fee rate for volume and durability.



Read it this way: Private Equity punches roughly 1.3× its weight in earnings; Credit & Insurance punches at about half its weight. Real Estate, despite shrinking assets, still delivers a third of segment profit — the legacy funds are harvesting.

Figure 2.2 — Assets versus profit, Q2 2026. Segment distributable earnings sum to \$2.20bn across the four segments. The ribbons show how each segment's share of the firm changes depending on whether you count assets or profits.

BY SIZE

Credit & Insurance. \$469bn, and the firm has explicitly named it the vehicle for the "next \$1 trillion." It also captures the structural shift of lending away from banks.

BY PROFIT

Private Equity. \$981m of segment earnings in a single quarter, up 31%. Highest fee rates, the carried interest, and the deals that get written about.

BY IDENTITY

Real Estate. Even at \$314bn and shrinking, it is the franchise Blackstone is most famous for, the one Jon Gray built, and the one that owns the data centres.

A QUESTION THIS SETS UP BEAUTIFULLY

"Credit and Insurance is now the largest segment by AUM but contributes a much smaller share of earnings, because the fee rate is lower. How does the firm think about that trade — is the bet that volume and durability more than compensate for the fee compression?"

The money machine

Blackstone has three revenue streams and two profit measures. If you understand which of them the market pays for and why, you understand the firm's entire strategy.

3.1 Three ways money arrives

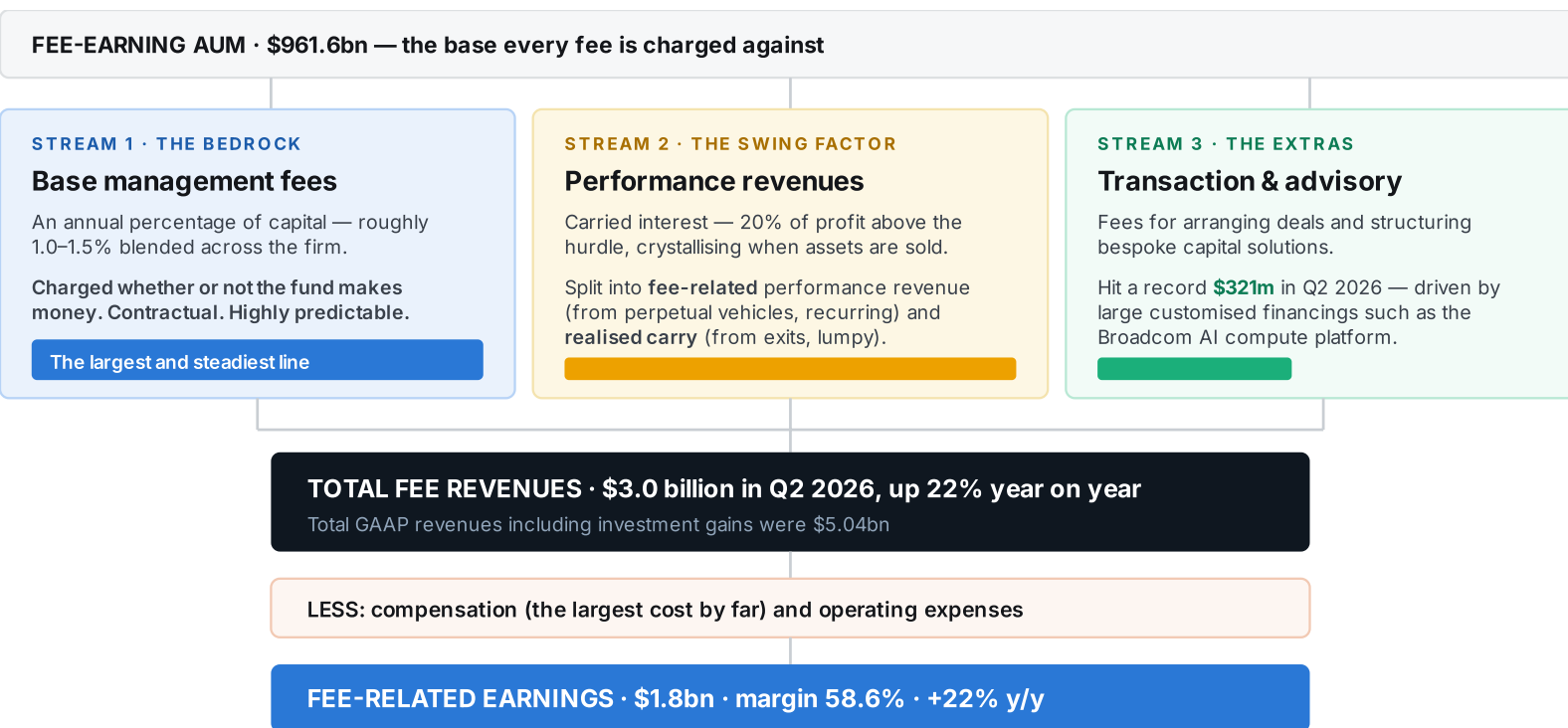


Figure 3.1 — The revenue architecture. Compensation is the dominant cost: this is a business whose main input is people. A 58.6% FRE margin means that for every pound of fee revenue, roughly 59 pence reaches operating profit — extraordinary for a services business, and the reason asset managers are valued the way they are.

3.2 FRE versus DE — the two numbers everyone quotes

These get used interchangeably by people who should know better. They are not the same thing, and the difference is the whole story of what Blackstone has been trying to become.

FEE-RELATED EARNINGS — \$1.8BN What it is: profit from management fees and recurring performance fees, after the costs of running the firm. It excludes anything that depends on selling an asset. Why it matters: it is recurring. A pound of FRE is worth far more to the share price than a pound of carried interest, because it will probably be there next year too. Analysts value Blackstone primarily on a multiple of FRE. Q2 2026: \$1.43 per share, up 22%, at a 58.6% margin — flat on the prior year, which management was pressed on: the richer revenue mix has not yet produced extra operating leverage.	DISTRIBUTABLE EARNINGS — \$2.0BN What it is: FRE <i>plus</i> realised carried interest and realised gains on Blackstone's own money, less tax and interest. It is the cash genuinely available to shareholders. Why it matters: Blackstone pays out essentially 100% of it as a dividend — a yield roughly four times the S&P 500's — plus a modest buyback. The dividend therefore moves with realisations. Q2 2026: \$1.52 per share, up 26%. Net realisations of \$414m, up 27%; gross performance revenues \$731m, up 32%.
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THE STRATEGIC POINT HIDING IN THAT COMPARISON

FRE is \$1.8bn of the \$2.0bn of distributable earnings — roughly 90%. Twenty years ago that ratio would have been far lower and the firm's earnings would have swung violently with the exit cycle. Deliberately shifting the mix from carry to fees is what has made Blackstone investable as a listed company. It is also the reason perpetual capital, insurance mandates and individual investors matter so much: all three produce fee income that does not depend on selling anything.

3.3 Where the growth is coming from

Year-on-year growth, Q2 2026 versus Q2 2025

The firm is growing fastest exactly where it has decided to grow fastest

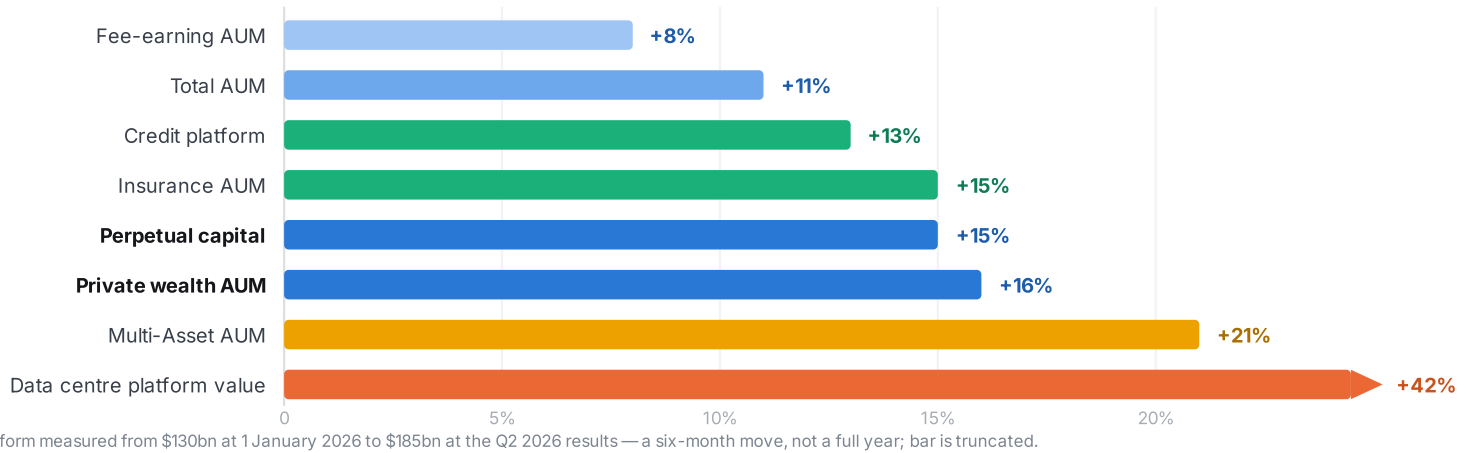


Figure 3.2 — Growth by line, Q2 2026. Read the ordering: everything Blackstone has strategically prioritised — perpetual capital, private wealth, insurance, multi-asset, digital infrastructure — is growing faster than the firm as a whole. That is not an accident; it is the plan working.

What management has told the market to expect

On the Q2 2026 call, CFO Michael Chae guided to **mid-single-digit base management fee growth in Q3**, stepping up to **double-digit growth in 2027**. The bridge to that acceleration: private equity funds activated during 2026 earning a full year of fees, perpetual strategies continuing to scale, credit stabilising with \$84bn of dry powder, and real estate fees finally ceasing to decline. On realisations, he flagged a slower Q3 but a strong Q4 and 2027, helped by eight IPOs on file globally and roughly a third of the corporate private equity portfolio now publicly traded.

Real Estate

\$314.1bn · down 3% year on year · \$745m of segment distributable earnings, up 32%. The world's largest owner of commercial real estate, and the franchise that made Jon Gray.

\$314bn

Segment AUM

\$30.4bn

BREP X — largest closed-end property fund ever raised

9.4%

BREIT net annualised return since inception

27%

Share of BREIT now in data centres

4.1 How it is built: three lanes of risk

Real estate is not one business but three, sold to different investors with different appetites. Understanding the three lanes is the fastest way to sound informed about property with anyone in the room.

LOWER RISK · LOWER RETURN · LONGER HOLD

Debt · BREDS

Blackstone lends against property rather than owning it. Paid first if things go wrong.

TARGET RETURN

High single digits, mostly from income

ALSO INCLUDES

BXMT, the separately listed mortgage trust

Core+ · BREIT and BPP

Already-good buildings, already let, held indefinitely for income plus modest growth.

TARGET RETURN

Low double digits

WHY IT MATTERS MOST TO YOU

This is where BREIT sits — perpetual, sold to individuals, monthly liquidity, gated at 5%

HIGHER RISK · HIGHER RETURN · SHORTER HOLD

Opportunistic · BREP

Broken, empty or badly run assets, bought cheaply, fixed, and sold within 3–7 years.

TARGET RETURN

High teens, mostly from capital gains

THE FLAGSHIP

BREP X raised \$30.4bn. BREP XI expected to come to market — a real test of appetite.

Return figures are indicative target ranges typical of each strategy type, not guarantees or stated Blackstone targets.

Figure 4.1 — The real estate risk spectrum. Every large property manager has some version of this ladder. Blackstone's distinction is that it is genuinely large in all three lanes at once, and that its core+ lane is sold directly to individuals rather than only to institutions.

4.2 Where it stands right now

The honest picture

Real estate has been Blackstone's problem child since interest rates rose in 2022, and the numbers show it: segment AUM fell 3% year on year, and base management fees declined as opportunistic funds harvested and institutional core-plus faced redemptions. Fund-level returns have reset hard — **BREP IX has come down to around a 7% net IRR from a peak near 47%, and BREP X sits near 10%.** Those are respectable absolute numbers and a brutal relative disappointment against what investors were shown in 2021.

Segment earnings nonetheless rose 32%, because harvesting older funds crystallises carried interest even as the asset base shrinks. Both facts are true at once, and being able to hold them together is a sign you have actually read the numbers.

Why Gray thinks the turn is here

- **Logistics is accelerating.** Leasing at Link, Blackstone's US warehouse platform, rose 26%. Gray calls logistics his favourite part of the real estate ecosystem.
- **Hotels are recovering.** US revenue per available room up around 5%.
- **Even office is bottoming.** New York vacancy has compressed from 21.5% to 14.5%, with seven straight quarters of positive net absorption nationally — though Gray is explicit that over-levered office owners remain in deep trouble. His formulation is worth borrowing: *"the recovery is real, just unevenly distributed."*
- **Financing has reopened.** CMBS issuance up 23%.
- **Borrowing costs** are down roughly 40% from their peaks.

THE TENSION TO BE AWARE OF

Private real estate marks have lagged listed REITs year to date. That gap is the crux of the bear argument: either private valuations are about to catch up, or they were never marked down far enough in the first place. Blackstone's answer is that BREIT has outperformed the public REIT index by roughly 40% since inception and that public markets are noisier, not wiser. It is a genuinely open question, and asking about it politely will land well.

Private Equity

\$454.2bn · up 17% · \$981m of segment distributable earnings, up 31% — the largest single earnings contributor in the firm.

\$20.7bn

Raised so far for BCP IX, the corporate flagship

\$13.1bn

Asia fund — largest ever, 2× the prior vintage

\$25bn

Strategic Partners secondaries — a record close

~1/3

Of the corporate PE portfolio now publicly traded

4.3 What sits inside

"Private equity" at Blackstone is a family of strategies, only one of which is the classic buyout fund.

STRATEGY	WHAT IT DOES	STATE OF PLAY, 2026
Corporate Private Equity (BCP)	Buys control of large established companies, improves them, sells them	BCP IX has raised \$20.7bn with a final close expected shortly — a big number, though flagship buyout fundraising industry-wide has been harder than in 2021
Core Equity	Same, but held for far longer at lower leverage and lower target return	Structurally growing; appeals to investors who want equity exposure without a ten-year exit clock
Asia Private Equity	Regional buyouts, India and Japan especially	Closed at \$13.1bn at its hard cap, more than double the prior fund, with a 27% net return on the predecessor
Infrastructure (BIP)	Power, transport, digital infrastructure — long-life, contracted assets	\$77bn+ of capital; the group behind much of the data centre and energy build-out
Energy Transition Partners	Grid, efficiency, cleaner power and the industrial supply chain around it	Latest flagship at \$6bn, on track for \$8.7bn. 2026 deals: Alliance Technical Group, Advanced Cooling Technologies, Dresser Utility Solutions
Tactical Opportunities	Deals that do not fit anywhere else — structured, opportunistic, cross-asset	The firm's flexible-mandate pool; often the vehicle for unusual situations
Life Sciences (BXLs)	Funds late-stage drug development in exchange for royalties	Niche but distinctive; very few competitors operate at this scale
Growth (BXG)	Minority stakes in fast-growing private companies	Smaller, later addition to the platform
Strategic Partners	Secondaries — buying existing fund stakes from investors who want out — plus GP-led deals and stakes in other managers	Closed a record \$25bn; \$14bn raised toward a \$22bn+ target for the next vintage. Over 1,900 transactions and 5,100 underlying fund interests to date

WHY STRATEGIC PARTNERS IS THE SMARTEST THING IN THIS SEGMENT

Secondaries buy fund stakes from investors who need liquidity. That means Blackstone sees the underlying performance data of thousands of other managers' funds — an information advantage no one else at this scale has. Folding the GP-stakes business into the same unit was deliberate: the secondaries data tells you which managers are worth owning a piece of. If you want one example of Blackstone thinking structurally rather than deal-by-deal, this is it.

Notable 2026 transactions

- **Champions Group** — residential services, roughly \$2.5bn, from Odyssey Investment Partners (February).
- **Aeroplan** — a 25% stake in Air Canada's loyalty business for C\$2.5bn, alongside Canadian pension funds CDPQ, BCI and PSP (August). A good illustration of Blackstone partnering with institutions rather than only taking their money.

- **Dresser Utility Solutions** — gas and water measurement infrastructure, from First Reserve; the first investment of the newest energy transition vintage (July).
- **Alliance Technical Group** — environmental testing and compliance, 2,200 staff across 60+ sites (January).

Credit & Insurance (BXCI)

\$469.3bn · up 15% · the largest segment by assets, the firm's stated route to its next trillion — and the one that had a very bad first quarter of 2026.

~\$550bn

Combined credit platform, up 13%

\$290bn

Insurance assets managed, up 15%

\$33bn

Q2 inflows — nearly half the whole firm's

\$84bn

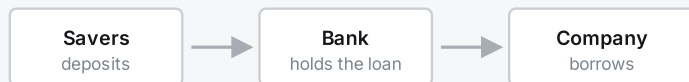
Credit dry powder, 2× early-2024 levels

4.4 The idea underneath it

BXCI exists because of a structural shift in how the world finances itself. After 2008, bank regulation made it expensive for banks to hold loans to mid-sized companies on their balance sheets. That lending did not disappear — it moved to asset managers funded by long-dated money. Blackstone's insight, and Apollo's before it, was that the natural funder of long-dated loans is a life insurer, whose liabilities are decades long.

Why private credit exists at all

THE OLD ROUTE — pre-2008



THE NEW ROUTE — where Blackstone sits



Why a borrower would choose the new route

- Speed and certainty — one lender, one negotiation, no syndication risk
- Size — a single cheque that would take a bank syndicate months
- Confidentiality — no public bond documentation
- Flexibility on covenants and structure

And why an insurer would choose Blackstone

- Private investment-grade credit offers, in Gray's words, "higher returns at the same or higher ratings levels" than liquid bonds
- Blackstone runs an **open-architecture** model — it manages money for insurers rather than buying them, so it does not compete with its clients

Figure 4.2 — The disintermediation trade. This one diagram explains roughly half of what has happened in finance since 2010, and it is the single most useful thing to understand if you want to sound current on credit.

4.5 The insurance franchise — the strategically important bit

Blackstone manages **\$290bn** for insurance companies and runs what it describes as the largest third-party-focused platform in the sector. The client count has grown to roughly **40 dedicated insurance relationships, nearly double two years ago**. The largest is Corebridge — AIG's former life and retirement business — where Blackstone managed \$71.2bn of book value at the end of 2025, rising to a contracted \$92.5bn by the third quarter of 2027. Corebridge is now merging with Equitable Holdings to form a group with more than \$1.5tn of assets under management and administration, which makes that relationship larger still.

In 2026 Blackstone added a partnership with **Nippon Life** of Japan, covering around \$10bn of private credit deployment over several years. Gray describes the whole trend as "structural" — insurers adopting private credit as a competitive necessity rather than an experiment.

THE DISTINCTION WORTH KNOWING COLD

Apollo *owns* its insurer (Athena). Blackstone *manages money for* insurers it does not own. That single difference — balance-sheet-heavy versus capital-light — is the defining strategic fork in the industry, and it comes up in Part 8. Blackstone's argument is that it can serve forty insurers precisely because it is not competing with any of them.

4.6 BCRED, and what happened in early 2026

BCRED — the Blackstone Private Credit Fund — is the world's largest private credit fund at roughly **\$82bn**. It is a non-traded business development company sold largely to individuals through financial advisers, offering quarterly liquidity capped at 5% of net asset value. In Q2 2026 it took \$1bn of gross sales but suffered **\$1.2bn of net outflows**, with repurchase requests exceeding the 5% cap and roughly half of requests filled. The full story of how that happened is in Part 7 — it is the most important live issue at the firm and worth reading before you go.

Multi-Asset Investing (BXMA)

\$108.6bn · up 21% · \$98m of segment earnings, up 35%. The smallest segment, the fastest-growing, and the one almost nobody outside the firm can describe.

4.7 What it actually does

BXMA was until recently called BAAM — Blackstone Alternative Asset Management — and it is the world's largest discretionary allocator to hedge funds. It does not run the trading strategies itself. Instead, a large institution hands BXMA a mandate and a risk objective, and BXMA constructs a bespoke portfolio of *external* hedge fund managers across equities, credit, macro and quantitative strategies, monitors them, negotiates fees on the client's behalf and reallocates as conditions change.

It also seeds emerging managers — providing early capital in exchange for a share of their economics — which gives Blackstone an early view of talent across the industry.

The segment is led by **Joe Dowling**, who ran Brown University's endowment before joining. That background matters: this business is closer to an outsourced chief investment officer than to a fund manager.

Why it is growing so fast

Institutions increasingly want one counterparty to solve a whole problem rather than twenty relationships to manage. BXMA sells solutions, not products, which is a much stickier proposition. On 1 July 2026 the business recorded **\$4.8bn of inflows in a single month — its best ever**.

The newest development is **BXHF**, a perpetual multi-strategy hedge fund built for wealth clients, which began accepting subscriptions in summer 2026. It is the same playbook the firm ran with BREIT and BCRED, applied to liquid strategies.

A QUESTION ALMOST NOBODY ASKS

"Multi-Asset Investing is the smallest segment but the fastest growing, and it just had its best month of inflows ever. Is that mostly institutions consolidating relationships, or is something changing in what clients want from hedge fund exposure?" — this signals that you read past the first three segments, which almost no student does.

The BXMA model

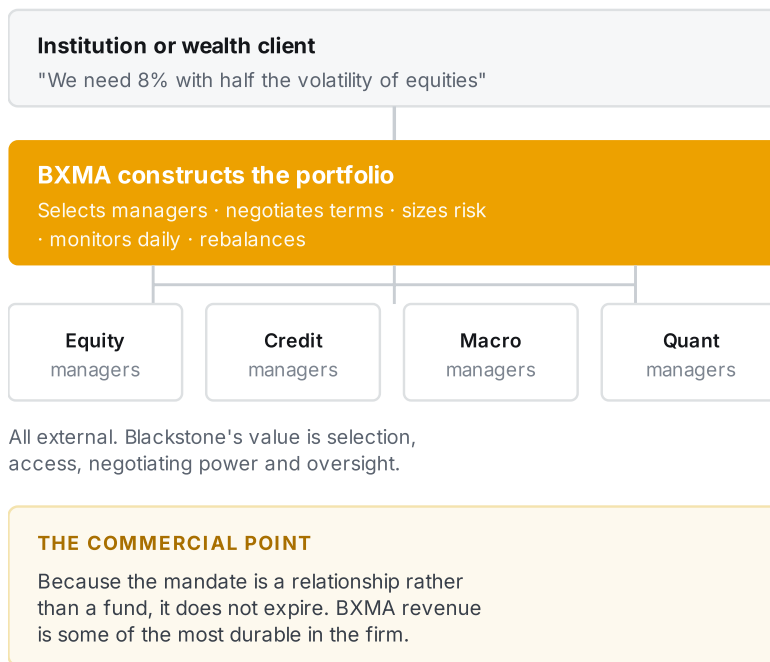


Figure 4.3 — Solutions, not products. The same logic — sell the answer, not the ingredient — increasingly runs through Insurance Solutions and Private Wealth too.

The client-facing franchise

Blackstone has two engines. One buys assets. The other raises and keeps the money that buys them. The second engine is younger, growing faster, and is where investor relations and client solutions live.

It is worth stating plainly why this side of the firm has become so important. An investment team can only deploy what it has been given. In a world where every large manager can hire good dealmakers, the scarce capability is *gathering and retaining capital at scale* — and increasingly, gathering it from investors who have never bought a private fund before. Blackstone raised roughly **\$260 billion in the twelve months to June 2026**. No investment team creates that; a distribution organisation does.

5.1 Three channels, three completely different jobs

1 · INSTITUTIONAL	2 · INSURANCE	3 · PRIVATE WEALTH
~\$730bn The historic core of the firm	\$290bn +15% ~40 dedicated insurance clients	\$324bn +16% A record; \$8.6bn of sales in Q2 alone
WHO YOU ARE TALKING TO Public and corporate pension funds, sovereign wealth funds, endowments and foundations, family offices, and large private banks investing on behalf of clients. <i>Professional investors with in-house teams and consultants advising them.</i>	 Chief investment officers and treasury teams at life insurers and annuity providers — Corebridge, Resolution Life, Everlake, Nippon Life and others. <i>Highly technical buyers constrained by capital rules and rating agencies.</i>	 Not, in most cases, the end investor — but their financial advisers : private banks, wirehouses, independent RIAs and wealth platforms who decide what to put on their approved list. <i>A distribution problem more than an investment one — and vastly more people.</i>
WHAT YOU ARE SELLING Commitments to closed-end funds — BREP, BCP, Strategic Partners — plus co-investment rights and separately managed accounts for the largest clients.	 Long-duration separately managed accounts, mostly investment-grade private credit, sized in the billions and contracted for years ahead.	 Perpetual, semi-liquid vehicles: BREIT, BCRED, BXPE, BXINFRA, BXHF and the new Wellington/Vanguard products — designed to be bought monthly.
THE RHYTHM OF THE JOB Campaign-based. An 18-month fundraise, then years of reporting and relationship maintenance until the next vintage. Deep, few, very large relationships.	 Project-based. Each mandate is a bespoke negotiation lasting months, then a multi-year partnership that expands. Technical, structural, slow-burn.	 Continuous. Money comes in and goes out every single month. Adviser education, seminars, platform approvals, content. Broad, many, always-on.

Figure 5.1 — The three capital channels. Institutional AUM is derived as total AUM less the disclosed insurance and private wealth figures, and there is some overlap between the categories; treat it as an order of magnitude, not a reported number. The three columns are genuinely different careers, and knowing which one you are drawn to is a real advantage in conversation.

Institutional Client Solutions

The classic investor relations function, at the largest scale in the industry.

5.2 What the job actually involves

Blackstone's Institutional Client Solutions organisation is not one team. It is a set of teams, some organised by client type and some by product. Job postings show, for example, a **Private Capital Group** covering single and multi-family offices, sophisticated registered investment advisers, and endowments and foundations — explicitly positioned to work *across every product Blackstone offers* rather than selling one fund. Separately there are ICS teams sitting inside BXMA and inside BXCI, each with their own client base and technical demands.

That structure tells you something important: Blackstone deliberately mixes *relationship coverage* (one person owns the client across everything) with *product specialism* (someone who genuinely understands credit sells credit). Reconciling those two is one of the perennial organisational tensions in any asset manager, and asking how they balance it is a legitimately sophisticated question.

What an analyst on these teams actually does

- **Coordinating responses to client enquiries** — a pension fund asks why a fund's mark moved; you find out, and you package the answer.
- **Preparing performance update calls** — the materials, the numbers, the anticipated questions.
- **Owning the contact cadence** so relationships do not go quiet between fundraises.
- **Producing client materials** with the investment teams — this is where you learn the actual portfolios.
- **Due diligence questionnaires (DDQs)** — long, exacting documents from institutional investors and their consultants.
- **Supporting fund closings**, including subscription documents and legal review.
- **Market and competitor research** to inform how a fund is positioned.
- **Cross-functional projects** to build out newer business lines.

Team sizes are small and flat — one posting describes working alongside roughly twelve people of varying seniority. That is the norm: a client-facing analyst gets real exposure to senior people and to clients much earlier than an equivalent hire in a large bank.

THE HONEST FRAMING OF THE ROLE, WHICH WILL IMPRESS

An investor relations professional at a firm like Blackstone is not a salesperson in the conventional sense. The product sells itself in good years. The job is **credibility management across a decade**: being the person who explains a disappointing quarter without spin, who knows the portfolio well enough to answer a CIO's question without going away to check, and who is still trusted when the next fund comes to market. Say something close to that and you will sound like you have thought about the work rather than the title.

5.3 Where an analyst sits in the capital-raising cycle

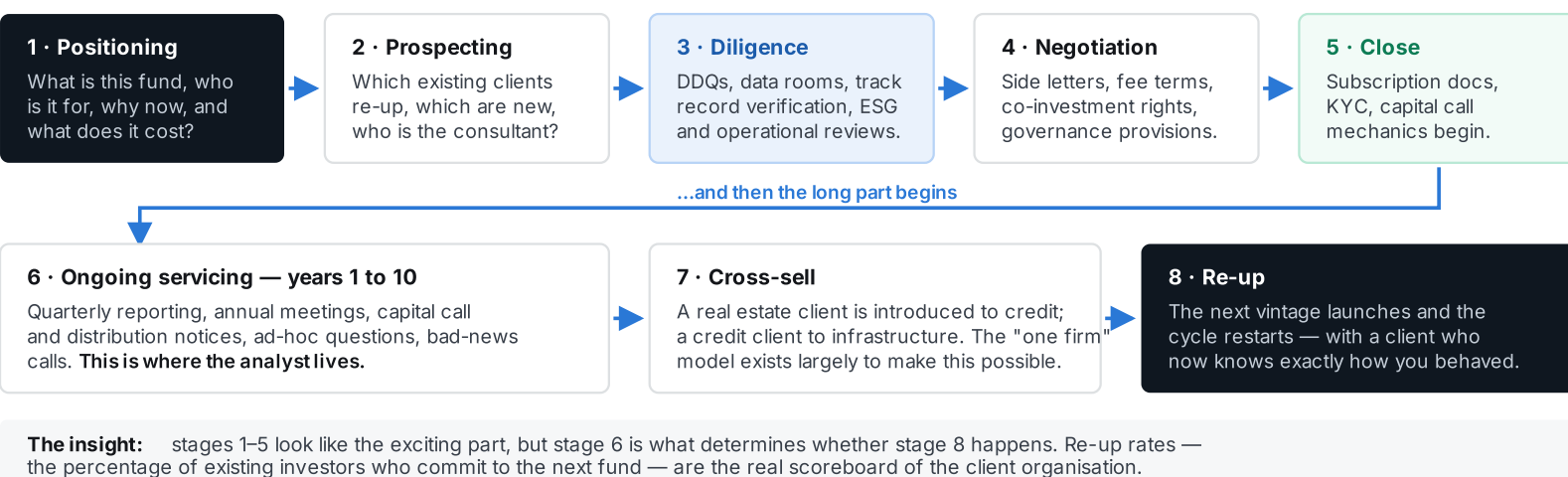


Figure 5.2 — The capital-raising cycle. Blackstone's scale means dozens of these run in parallel at any moment across the four segments.

Private Wealth Solutions

\$324bn and growing 16% a year. The most consequential thing Blackstone has built in a decade, led by Joan Solotar, a member of the firm's Management Committee.

5.4 The strategic logic

Institutional investors have been allocating to private markets for forty years and are, broadly, full. A large US pension might already hold 15% of its portfolio in alternatives. Individual investors — even wealthy ones — typically hold a low single-digit percentage. If that share moves even a few points, the flow of money dwarfs anything the institutional channel can add.

The obstacle was structural. A traditional ten-year drawdown fund with capital calls at unpredictable moments and no way out is simply unsuitable for an individual. So Blackstone re-engineered the product. The result is the **perpetual, semi-liquid vehicle** — and understanding its mechanics is genuinely the most useful technical knowledge you can bring to a conversation with anyone on this side of the firm.

Anatomy of a semi-liquid perpetual vehicle — how BREIT, BCRED and BXPE work

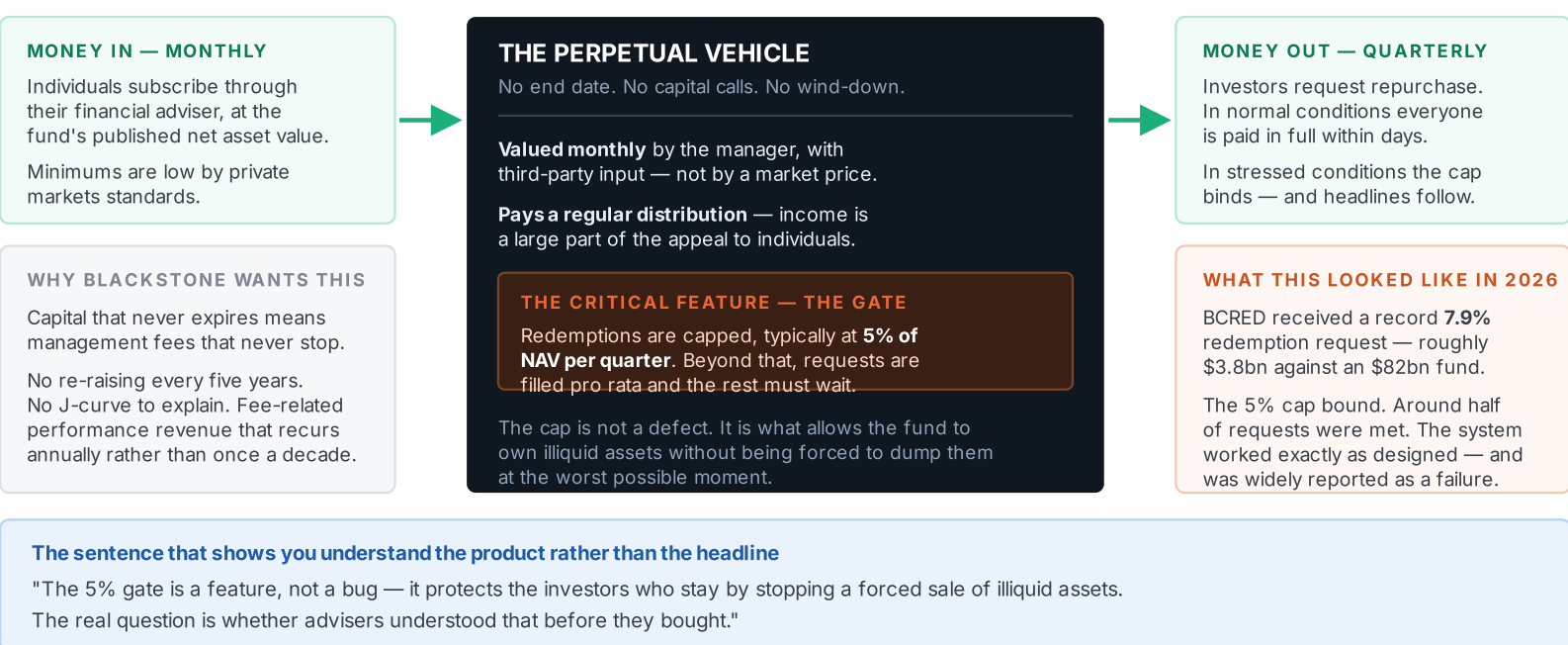


Figure 5.3 — The semi-liquid vehicle. This structure is the single biggest product innovation in alternatives since the 1980s, and it is the source of both Blackstone's fastest growth and its most acute reputational risk.

5.5 The product shelf

VEHICLE	WHAT IT HOLDS	WHERE IT STANDS, Q2 2026	WHY IT MATTERS
BXPE Private Equity Strategies	Private equity, across Blackstone's strategies	\$2.4bn raised in the quarter; NAV above \$25bn after ten quarters , roughly doubling year on year; 20% annualised net return since inception in its largest share class	The success story. Launched in 2024 and already a top-tier vehicle
BREIT Real Estate Income Trust	Core+ property — rental housing, logistics, and now 27% data centres	\$1.2bn raised; repurchase requests down 42% year on year; best net flows in four years; 9.4% net annualised since inception, ~40% ahead of the public REIT index	The original, and the vehicle that survived a redemption crisis in 2022–23 with its structure intact
BCRED Private Credit Fund	Direct lending to mid-size and large companies	\$82bn; \$1.2bn net outflows in Q2 on \$1bn of gross sales; redemption requests reported "down materially" in early Q3	The world's largest private credit fund, and the epicentre of the 2026 scare
BXINFRA Infrastructure	Power, transport, digital infrastructure	\$900m raised; \$6bn NAV in six quarters ; 16% annualised net return	Fastest ramp of the newer vehicles; rides the AI-power theme directly
BXDC Digital Infrastructure Trust	Data centres	IPO priced May 2026 — 87.5m shares at \$20, raising up to \$2bn: the largest blind-pool REIT IPO ever	A pure-play listed route into AI infrastructure. Schwarzman has floated the data centre market reaching "\$1 trillion over time"
BXHF Multi-Strategy	Liquid hedge fund strategies via BXMA	Opened for subscriptions in summer 2026	Extends the perpetual model into liquid markets
WVB funds with Wellington & Vanguard	Blended public and private portfolios	WVB All Markets and WVB Blackstone All Privates launched in 2026	Deliberately designed to reach investors below the "qualified purchaser" threshold — a much larger population

NOTE FOR A LONDON CONVERSATION

Several of these have non-US equivalents — BXPE is offered to non-US investors through a Luxembourg SICAV structure, and there is a European private credit vehicle alongside BCRED. If you are talking to someone in the London private wealth team, asking how the European product set and regulatory regime differs from the US one is a precise, informed question that a generalist would never think to ask.

What these careers actually look like

And what "good" looks like in them — useful both for the conversation tonight and for deciding whether you want the job.

5.6 The skills that separate people in client-facing roles

INVESTMENT FLUENCY, NOT INVESTMENT WORK

You will not build the model. You must be able to explain, unprompted and accurately, why a fund's return moved, what the portfolio is exposed to, and what would have to happen for the thesis to fail. Clients can tell within ninety seconds whether you understand the asset or are reading from a deck.

PRECISION UNDER PRESSURE

A number sent to a sovereign wealth fund is effectively a representation about the firm. Client-facing analysts operate under a level of accuracy discipline closer to compliance than to sales. Errors are expensive and remembered.

COMFORT DELIVERING BAD NEWS

The defining moment of the role is a quarter where a fund is down, a gate has been hit, or a headline has run. The people who thrive are those who call the client *first* rather than waiting to be asked.

INSTITUTIONAL NAVIGATION

Most of the work is getting the right answer out of a busy deal team, a legal team and a finance team, and assembling it into something a client can act on. Internal credibility is what makes external credibility possible.

How the paths typically run

LEVEL	WHAT YOU OWN	WHAT CHANGES
Analyst years 1–3	Materials, data, DDQ responses, meeting preparation, CRM discipline, and increasingly your own smaller relationships	You learn the products properly. This is the year of getting everything right.
Associate years 3–5	Named accounts, running the process on a fundraise workstream, drafting rather than assembling	You start being in the room, then leading parts of it.
Vice President	A book of clients, and responsibility for what they commit	You are now measured on outcomes, not output.
Principal / Managing Director	A region, a channel or a segment; senior relationship ownership at CIO level	The job becomes judgement and access rather than execution.

Titles and timings vary by team and are indicative of industry norms rather than a published Blackstone framework.

5.7 What Blackstone says it looks for

The firm's own language is consistent across postings: people who "work well in a team-driven working group," are "highly motivated," show "sound judgment" and have "demonstrated excellence in prior endeavors." Recruiting commentary is blunter — Blackstone weights cultural fit heavily, and the informal description that circulates is that it hires *people who are genuinely pleasant to work with and also relentless about execution*. Independent thinking is explicitly valued; the firm's stated culture is one where "the best ideas win regardless of hierarchy."

For campus routes, the process typically runs: application, an online assessment and recorded video interview, interviews, then a final round. Technical questions exist even for non-investment roles, and the folk wisdom is unforgiving — get the accounting right, because a slip there is treated as disqualifying.

HOW TO USE THIS TONIGHT

Do not ask "what do you look for in a candidate?" — everyone asks it and the answer is always the same. Ask instead: **"What separates the analysts on your team who become great client people from the ones who stay merely competent?"** That question gets a real answer, because it is about their team rather than about you.

Leadership, governance and culture

Who runs what, why the firm is shaped this way, and how decisions actually get made.

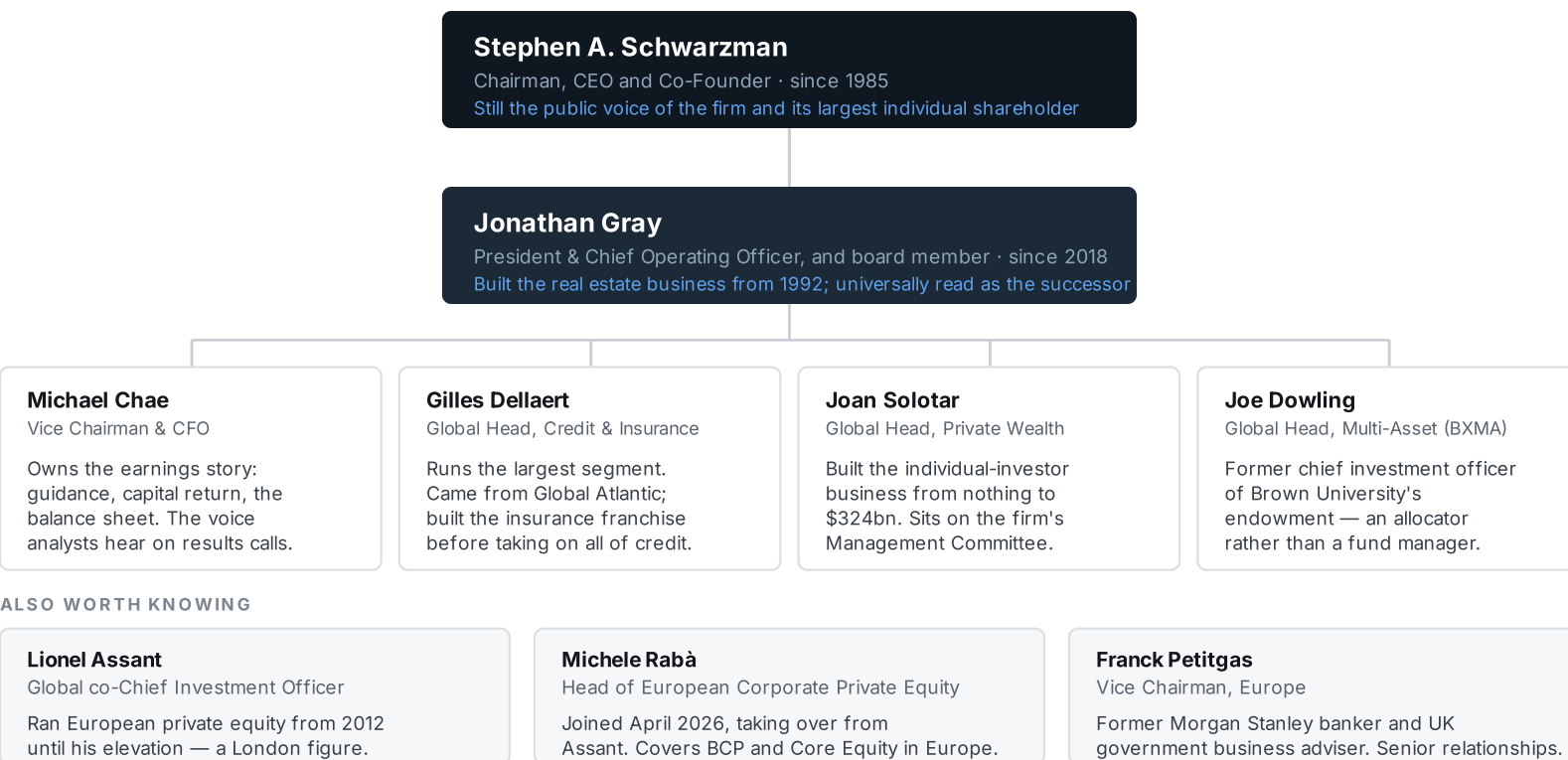


Figure 6.1 — The people whose names you should recognise. Also worth knowing: John Finley, Chief Legal Officer; Vik Sawhney, Chief Administrative Officer; John Stecher, Chief Technology Officer; Dan Leiter, Head of International for BXCI; Abhishek Agarwal, Head of Core+ for EMEA and Asia-Pacific, based in London.

6.1 Why the firm is structured this way

One firm, deliberately

Blackstone could have grown as a holding company of semi-independent boutiques. It chose not to. The segments share a capital-raising organisation, a technology group, a portfolio operations team and a single brand. The commercial payoff is cross-sell: a real estate client can be introduced to credit without a new sales relationship being built from scratch. The cultural payoff is that information travels — the credit team's view of a sector informs the buyout team's underwriting.

The 2023 integration of credit and insurance

Blackstone merged its credit arm (the descendant of GSO) with Blackstone Insurance Solutions to create BXCI. The logic is elegant: insurance provides long-dated liabilities looking for yield; private credit originates long-dated assets that provide it. Running them as one unit means the people raising insurance money and the people originating loans share a single view of supply and demand. The firm explicitly framed the move as the vehicle for its "next \$1 trillion."

How decisions get made

Blackstone's investment process is built around written analysis and structured debate. Deal teams produce a memo; an investment committee interrogates it; the discussion starts with what can go wrong rather than what could go right. The firm's own description of its culture emphasises "rigorous debate, written analysis, a strong focus on downside risk, and a culture where the best ideas win regardless of hierarchy."

The important consequence is that *anyone in the room can object*. Schwarzman has built four decades of messaging around not losing money, and the committee format exists to make caution socially acceptable rather than career-limiting. If you want a single question that shows you understand the firm as an organisation rather than a brand, ask how that actually works in practice when a deal has momentum behind it.

Governance you should know

Blackstone converted from a partnership to a corporation in 2019, which opened it to index funds and broadened its shareholder base considerably. Schwarzman retains ²⁷

substantial control; this is a founder-led public company, not a widely-held one.

What is actually happening right now

Five live storylines. If any of them comes up tonight and you can respond with specifics, you will be the best-briefed person in the room who is not paid to be.

7.1 The AI infrastructure land grab

This is the dominant story at Blackstone in 2026, and it is bigger than most people outside the firm realise. Schwarzman told investors in July that Blackstone has "become one of the largest private capital providers in the AI ecosystem." The data centre platform is now valued at roughly **\$185 billion, up from \$130 billion at the start of the year**, and the firm expects to lease three times more data centre capacity in 2026 than in any prior year.

The foundation was laid earlier: QTS was acquired in 2021 and taken from the fifth-largest North American data centre operator to the largest in three years, and AirTrunk was bought for **A\$24 billion**, bringing the leading Asia-Pacific platform with it. What is new is the scale and variety of what Blackstone is now doing around those assets.

The AI build-out, and where Blackstone sits in it

Blue boxes are layers where Blackstone has taken a direct position



How they get paid, and the argument for why this is not just a bubble trade

Jon Gray's framing: "demand for compute is outpacing supply because of power and chip entitlement constraints." Blackstone is not betting on any single model company winning. It owns the **scarce physical input** — powered land — and leases it under long contracts to the largest credit counterparties in the world. If AI spending disappoints, the leases still run. That is the bull case; the bear case is that "long leases to great counterparties" is what everyone says before an overbuild.

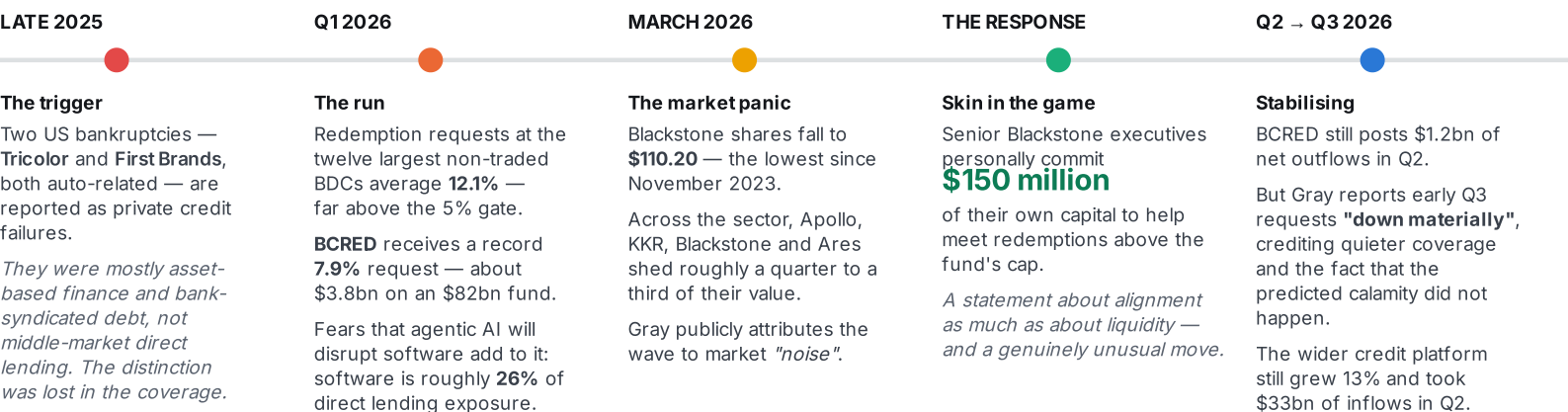
Two more datapoints worth carrying

- **BXDC** — the Blackstone Digital Infrastructure Trust — IPO'd in May 2026 at \$20 a share, raising up to \$2bn. It was the largest blind-pool REIT IPO ever, and it gives public and wealth investors a direct route into the data centre theme.
- **Pennsylvania** — Blackstone committed more than \$25bn to digital and energy infrastructure in the state, and says it expects to catalyse a further \$60bn. QTS has assembled multiple sites in the north-east of the state — the clearest example of the power-plus-buildings strategy in one place.

Figure 7.1 — Blackstone's position across the AI stack. The strategic idea is to own the layers where scarcity is physical and contracts are long, and to lend rather than own where technology risk is highest.

The private credit stress test of 2026

The most important thing that has happened to Blackstone this year, and the subject on which having an actual view will distinguish you most.



How to think about it — hold all three of these at once

1. The structure worked. Gates exist precisely so that a fund holding illiquid loans is never forced to sell them cheaply. Nobody was wiped out.
2. The distribution question is real and unresolved. If advisers and their clients treated a gated vehicle as though it were a bond fund, that is a suitability problem, not a market problem — and it sits squarely with the private wealth channel that has driven so much of the growth.
3. The credit question is separate and still open. Defaults are rising from artificially low levels, and 26% software exposure in a world of agentic AI is a genuine underwriting issue that has not yet been tested by a recession.

Figure 7.2 — The 2026 private credit episode. Note the shape: an event in one corner of credit, amplified by coverage, transmitted through a retail product structure, into a sector-wide share price fall. That transmission mechanism — retail money in semi-liquid vehicles — did not exist at this scale five years ago.

THE BEST QUESTION IN THIS WHOLE REPORT

"The gates on BCRED did exactly what they were designed to do, but the episode still cost the sector a third of its market value. Has it changed how Blackstone thinks about educating the wealth channel — or about how much of the firm's growth should come from semi-liquid products at all?"

Why it works: it is specific, it is not hostile, it concedes the firm's own best argument before asking the hard part, and it goes straight to the strategic tension inside the business you say you want to join.

Three more live storylines

7.3 The retirement frontier — potentially the biggest prize of all

In August 2025 a US executive order directed regulators to make it easier for private assets to sit inside 401(k) retirement plans. That opened, in principle, a defined-contribution market of roughly **\$13–14 trillion** — an order of magnitude larger than the private wealth channel Blackstone has spent a decade building.

Blackstone has moved quickly on three fronts:

- **A dedicated unit.** The firm created a group specifically to build products for the defined-contribution market and manage the partnerships that distribute them.
- **Wellington and Vanguard.** A three-way alliance announced in April 2026, producing blended public-private products — WVB All Markets and WVB Blackstone All Privates — explicitly designed to reach investors below the qualified-purchaser threshold. Partnering with Vanguard, the standard-bearer of low-cost passive investing, is a striking piece of legitimising strategy.
- **Empower.** Blackstone joined the investment partnership programme of one of the largest US retirement plan administrators, distributing private exposure through collective investment trust structures.

The counter-argument is loud and worth knowing: retirement advisers and consumer advocates argue that illiquid, harder-to-value, higher-fee assets do not belong in a default retirement account, and that the 2026 credit episode is exactly the evidence for that view. Regulators are still working through it. This is the single most consequential open policy question for the industry.

7.4 Selected 2026 activity — what the firm has actually been doing

WHEN	WHAT	WHY IT IS INTERESTING
January	Alliance Technical Group acquired	Environmental testing and compliance — 2,200 staff, 60+ sites. Unglamorous, essential, regulated services: a classic energy-transition-adjacent buyout
February	Champions Group , ~\$2.5bn	Residential services roll-up bought from another sponsor — evidence that sponsor-to-sponsor M&A is functioning again
March	Advanced Cooling Technologies , majority stake	Thermal management manufacturing. Cooling is a direct bottleneck in data centre construction — the AI theme expressed through industrials
April	Wellington / Vanguard alliance launches	The retail and retirement strategy made concrete
May	BXDC IPO priced at \$20/share	Up to \$2bn raised; the largest blind-pool REIT IPO on record
July	Dresser Utility Solutions from First Reserve	First deal of the newest energy transition vintage — gas and water measurement infrastructure
July	Nippon Life insurance partnership	~\$10bn of private credit deployment over several years; extends the insurance model into Japan
August	Aeroplan — 25% stake, C\$2.5bn	Air Canada's loyalty programme, bought alongside CDPQ, BCI and PSP. Blackstone as co-investor with pension funds rather than only their manager
August	Knowledge Realty Trust stake sale, up to \$1.25bn	Selling down an Indian office REIT position — its largest such transaction of the year, and a reminder that realisations matter as much as acquisitions
August	\$3bn CFO deal shelved	Blackstone weighed abandoning a collateralised fund obligation backed by an older secondaries fund with ~700 underlying investments. A rare public sign of financing markets not cooperating
Ongoing	Big Yellow — potential £2.2bn+ bid	The UK's largest self-storage business. A live, very visible London-relevant situation
Ongoing	Indurent exit explored, ~£6bn	The UK logistics platform Blackstone created in 2024, with over £1bn invested this year, now weighing a London listing or sale

Deal values and statuses are as reported in the press at the time; several remain under negotiation and may not complete.

7.5 The share price problem

Blackstone's operating results in 2026 have been strong, and its share price has not reflected that. The stock opened the year around **\$154**, fell to **\$110** in the March credit panic, and was trading near **\$143** at the end of August — down roughly 7.5% year to date and well below its 52-week high of \$190. On the day of the Q2 beat, the shares fell slightly.

The market is not disputing the earnings; it is disputing the durability of the growth. Three worries sit underneath: that private credit spreads and volumes normalise from an exceptional period, that real estate fee income keeps declining, and that the semi-liquid retail model has a fragility the 2026 episode exposed.

Schwarzman's response on the results call was characteristically unhedged: the stock is "on sale," and Blackstone is "one of the most inexpensive ways to participate in this extraordinary mega-trend" of AI and infrastructure. Management has committed to distributing essentially all cash earnings as dividends, at a yield roughly four times the S&P 500's, plus a moderate buyback.

THE NUMBERS

Start of 2026	\$154.20
March low	\$110.20
28 August 2026	\$142.63
52-week high	\$190.09
Analyst target (avg)	~\$149
Market cap	~\$107bn

Market capitalisation figures for Blackstone vary widely by source depending on whether they include units not held by the public — treat the number as approximate.

HANDLE WITH CARE

Bringing up the share price is fine and shows you follow the firm. Do *not* lead with it, and do not say anything that sounds like you think the firm is in trouble. Frame it as a question about how management thinks about the gap between operating performance and market perception.

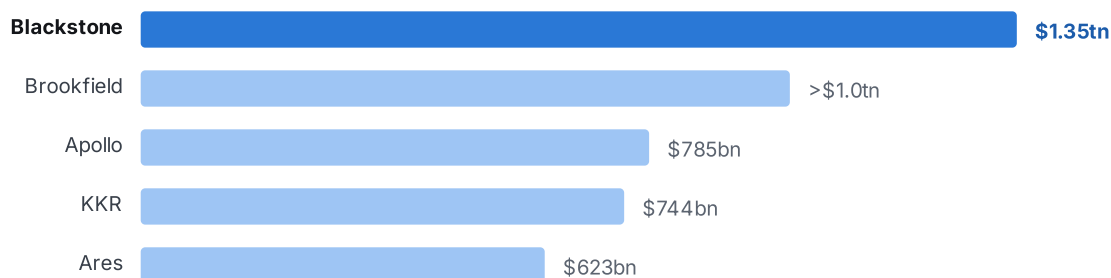
Where Blackstone is genuinely different

Everyone at a networking evening can say "Blackstone is the biggest." The useful knowledge is how it is different from Apollo, KKR, Brookfield and Ares — because those differences are strategic choices, not accidents of size.

8.1 The scoreboard

Assets under management, 2026

Blackstone as at Q2 2026; peers as most recently reported. AUM definitions differ by firm — directionally right, not precisely comparable.



But size is not momentum. Apollo's fee-earning AUM grew roughly **44%** over the last year against Blackstone's **11%**. If someone raises this, the fair answer is that the two firms are growing different things: Apollo's growth is largely insurance balance-sheet assets at low fee rates, while Blackstone's is spread across four segments at materially higher ones.

Figure 8.1 — The Big Five by scale. Note that "AUM" is not standardised across firms; Brookfield in particular includes assets held on its own balance sheet. Comparisons are directional.

8.2 The strategic fork that defines the industry

This is the most valuable single idea in this section. Faced with the same opportunity — insurance money funding private credit — the major firms took two genuinely different routes.

ROUTE A — CAPITAL LIGHT

Manage other people's insurers

Blackstone · Brookfield (partly)

Blackstone signs long-term mandates to manage portions of insurers' portfolios — Corebridge, Resolution Life, Everlake, Nippon Life and ~36 others.

The advantages

- No insurance liabilities on Blackstone's balance sheet
- No regulatory capital requirement, no ratings risk
- Open architecture — it is not competing with clients, so forty insurers can all hire it

The cost

- Lower fee rates, and mandates can be lost

ROUTE B — BALANCE SHEET

Own the insurer outright

Apollo (Athene) · KKR (Global Atlantic)

Apollo merged with Athene; KKR bought Global Atlantic. The manager now owns the liabilities it invests against.

The advantages

- Captive, permanent capital that cannot be fired
- Captures the full spread, not just a management fee
- Explosive AUM growth — Apollo's fee-earning assets grew ~44% in a year

The cost

- Real insurance risk, regulatory capital and rating agency scrutiny sit on the firm itself

The concentration point: Apollo takes ~86% of fee-earning assets and 72% of base fees from credit and insurance; Ares 66% and 65%; KKR 48% and 30%. Blackstone, at roughly a third of AUM in credit and insurance, is the most diversified of the group.

Figure 8.2 — Two answers to the same question. Neither is obviously right. Blackstone's bet is that being a trusted manager to the whole insurance industry beats being one insurer; Apollo's bet is that owning the liability is worth the risk.

8.3 Five things Blackstone does that others genuinely do not

1 · REAL DIVERSIFICATION

Roughly a third in credit and insurance, a third in private equity, a quarter in real estate. Apollo and Ares are credit houses with other businesses attached. When one asset class breaks, Blackstone's earnings bend rather than snap — visible this year, where credit earnings fell 6% while private equity and real estate rose over 30%.

2 · THE PRIVATE WEALTH MACHINE

\$324bn is a bigger individual-investor franchise than any competitor has built, and it was built first. BREIT and BCRED were the templates the entire industry copied. That first-mover position is why Vanguard and Wellington chose Blackstone as a partner.

3 · PHYSICAL AI INFRASTRUCTURE AT SCALE

Owning QTS and AirTrunk and controlling 15 gigawatts of entitled powered land is not something a competitor can replicate quickly — it took a decade of real estate and infrastructure capability to get there. This is the boldest position Blackstone holds that peers do not.

4 · WILLINGNESS TO WRITE THE BIGGEST CHEQUE

The \$35bn Broadcom platform is the largest private credit investment ever made. Very few institutions on earth can commit at that size at speed — and scarcity of capacity translates directly into pricing power and transaction fees.

5 · SECONDARIES PLUS GP STAKES UNDER ONE ROOF

Strategic Partners has closed over 1,900 secondaries transactions covering more than 5,100 underlying fund interests. That is a proprietary dataset on how thousands of other managers' funds actually perform — and Blackstone deliberately runs its GP-stakes business alongside it so the data informs which managers to own a piece of. It is a structural information edge, not a deal-by-deal one.

8.4 And where it is vulnerable

- **Fee compression.** Growth is concentrated in the lowest-fee parts of the firm. FRE margin was flat at 58.6% despite a richer mix — analysts noticed and asked about it.
- **Real estate exposure.** A quarter of AUM in an asset class where fund IRRs have reset from 47% to 7%, and where BREP XI has yet to prove that investors will re-up at the old scale.
- **Retail fragility.** The semi-liquid model transmits sentiment into flows within weeks. Institutional capital cannot run; wealth capital can, and in Q1 it did.
- **Slower growth than Apollo** on the headline AUM measure, which invites an unflattering comparison even when the underlying mix is better.

Europe, and the building you are walking into

40 Berkeley Square is Blackstone's European headquarters. Knowing what actually happens there is worth more tonight than any amount of global statistics.

650+

London headcount, having more than doubled in three years

\$350bn+

Blackstone assets across Europe

\$500bn

Of European investment opportunity the firm says it sees over the next decade

~20 yrs

Of Blackstone presence in London

9.1 What the London office does

London is not a satellite sales office. It is the operating centre for Blackstone's business across Europe, the Middle East and Africa, and it houses investment teams as well as client-facing and infrastructure functions. The UK is Blackstone's second-largest employee base after the United States.

Leadership relevant to a European conversation:

- **Michele Rabà** — Head of European Corporate Private Equity since April 2026, running both the flagship Blackstone Capital Partners strategy and the longer-dated Core Equity strategy in Europe.
- **Lionel Assant** — ran European private equity from 2012 until his elevation to Global co-Chief Investment Officer. A London-grown senior figure, and a good illustration that European roles lead to global ones.
- **Franck Petitgas** — Vice Chairman, Europe. Former Morgan Stanley banker and UK government business adviser; the senior relationship figure.
- **Abhishek Agarwal** — Head of Core+ for EMEA and Asia-Pacific, based in London.
- **Dan Leiter** — Head of International for Blackstone Credit & Insurance.

9.2 The UK situations that are live right now

These are the ones a London employee is most likely to be following, and they make excellent conversational openings because they are local, current and interesting.

SITUATION	WHAT IS HAPPENING
Indurent	The UK industrial and logistics platform Blackstone created in February 2024. Over £1bn invested into scaling it this year, and the firm is now exploring a London listing or a sale at a valuation reported around £6bn . A textbook example of the "buy, build a platform, exit as a company rather than a portfolio" strategy
Big Yellow Group	Blackstone has confirmed it is considering a bid for the UK's largest self-storage operator, at a price reported at £2.2bn or more . A public-to-private of a listed UK REIT would be a significant statement about UK valuations
Last-mile logistics	A portfolio of 18 assets near Manchester, Birmingham, Reading and Leeds bought from PGIM for around £200m , while separately selling roughly \$1.3bn of other UK logistics assets. Blackstone is trading within the sector, not just accumulating
Pan-European logistics	A €1bn joint venture with Burstone Group, plus a €500m portfolio of Czech logistics assets. Logistics is Jon Gray's stated favourite sector and Europe is where the platform is being built

TWO LONDON-SPECIFIC QUESTIONS WORTH HAVING READY

For a real estate person: "Indurent seems to be the platform-building playbook done in the UK from scratch. Is a London listing genuinely attractive at the moment, or is a sale the more likely route given where UK REITs trade?"

For anyone: "The London office has more than doubled in three years. What has that growth actually been in — is it investment teams, or is it the client and infrastructure side catching up with the scale of European capital?"

The criticisms, and how to hold them

You do not need to raise any of this tonight. You do need to not be blindsided by it, and to be able to discuss it fairly if a conversation turns serious.

10.1 Housing and the landlord question

Blackstone is one of the largest residential landlords in the world, with roughly 350,000 US rental units, and this attracts sustained criticism. The specific charges: aggressive rent increases — at some San Diego properties acquired in 2021, rents rose about 38% against a market average near 20% — and the use of algorithmic pricing software. In December 2025 the US Department of Justice reached a settlement with Blackstone's LivCor subsidiary over allegations that it and other landlords set rents using shared competitively-sensitive information through common pricing algorithms. The RealPage software at the centre of that case is now banned in several US states and cities. A UN special rapporteur has previously criticised the firm's role in housing affordability, and US legislators have proposed bills to restrict private equity ownership of rental housing.

The counter-argument, which Blackstone and its defenders make, is that institutional owners are a small share of the total housing stock, that they add supply through development and renovation rather than removing it, and that housing costs are driven overwhelmingly by planning restrictions and undersupply. Both things can be true: institutional capital is not the cause of a housing shortage, and individual landlords can still behave badly within one.

10.2 The private credit critique

The serious version of this argument is not that private credit will blow up tomorrow. It is that: assets are valued by the manager rather than by a market; the sector grew enormously during a period of unusually low defaults; leverage has migrated somewhere less visible to regulators rather than disappearing; and semi-liquid vehicles create a liquidity mismatch between what investors think they own and what the fund actually holds. Coverage in 2026 has been pointed — one widely-read piece described private credit's "zero-loss fantasy" coming to an end as defaults and fund exits rose.

The counter-argument is that gates worked exactly as designed, that direct lending's actual loss experience through the episode was far better than the headlines implied, that Tricolor and First Brands were not middle-market direct lending failures at all, and that a lender who holds the whole loan has more incentive to underwrite carefully than one who originates to distribute.

10.3 The structural critiques

FEES AND NET RETURNS

The long-running academic argument is that after fees, the median private equity fund does not beat public equity on a risk- and leverage-adjusted basis.

Blackstone's response is that it is not the median fund — and its flagship track record supports that — but the general point about dispersion in the industry is well founded.

LEVERAGE AND EMPLOYMENT

Buyouts use debt, and debt makes companies fragile. The critique is that this transfers risk onto employees and suppliers. The defence is that operational improvement, not leverage, has driven the majority of returns in modern buyouts, and that Blackstone's portfolio operations group exists precisely to make that true.

RETAIL SUITABILITY

The strongest live critique. Selling illiquid, hard-to-value, higher-fee assets to individuals — and potentially into default retirement accounts — is a genuine policy question that has not been settled, and the 2026 redemption episode is the exhibit for the prosecution.

SYSTEMIC OPACITY

As lending moves from regulated banks to asset managers, supervisors see less. Blackstone would argue that risk sitting in long-dated, unlevered or lightly-levered funds is safer than the same risk sitting in a deposit-funded bank. That is a reasonable argument, and it has not yet been tested by a real recession.

HOW TO HANDLE THIS IF IT COMES UP

The winning posture is neither defensive nor critical — it is *interested*. "I've read the criticism about semi-liquid vehicles and retail suitability, and I can see both sides — the gates clearly protected the investors who stayed, but the episode also showed how fast sentiment moves through that channel. How does the firm think about that internally?" That is a serious question asked respectfully, and it is the kind of thing that makes someone remember you.

Your event playbook

Everything above, compressed into what you can actually use between 18:00 and 20:00. If you re-read one section on the way there, make it this one.

11.1 Ten facts to have on the tip of your tongue

1 · THE HEADLINE

\$1.35 trillion AUM at Q2 2026, up 11%. Distributable earnings \$2.0bn, up 26%. Fee-related earnings \$1.8bn, up 22%.

2 · THE SHAPE

Credit & Insurance \$469bn · Private Equity \$454bn · Real Estate \$314bn · Multi-Asset \$109bn.

3 · THE STRATEGIC NUMBER

Perpetual capital \$555.6bn, up 15% — capital with no end date, growing faster than the firm.

4 · THE AI POSITION

Largest data centre owner in the world. Platform value ~\$185bn, up from \$130bn in January. 15 gigawatts of entitled powered land.

5 · THE RECORD DEAL

\$35bn Broadcom financing platform with Apollo — the largest private credit investment ever made, for 1GW of AI compute.

6 · THE WEALTH BUSINESS

\$324bn, up 16%. BXPE reached \$25bn NAV in ten quarters at a 20% annualised net return. Led by Joan Solotar.

7 · THE STRESS POINT

BCRED took a record 7.9% redemption request (~\$3.8bn) in Q1; executives put in \$150m of their own money; requests are now "down materially."

8 · THE INSURANCE FRANCHISE

\$290bn managed for ~40 insurance clients, nearly double two years ago. Blackstone manages insurers' money rather than owning insurers — unlike Apollo.

9 · THE LONDON FACT

650+ people at 40 Berkeley Square, more than doubled in three years. \$350bn+ of European assets; \$500bn of opportunity seen over a decade.

10 · THE PEOPLE

Schwarzman (Chairman & CEO, co-founder 1985), Jon Gray (President & COO, built real estate), Michael Chae (CFO), Gilles Dellaert (BXCI), Joan Solotar (Private Wealth), Joe Dowling (BXMA).

11.2 Questions, tiered by who you are standing in front of

Pick two or three. Do not interview them. The best outcome of any of these is that they talk for four minutes and you listen properly.

IF YOU MEET SOMEONE IN PRIVATE WEALTH SOLUTIONS OR CLIENT SOLUTIONS

"The gates on BCRED did exactly what they were designed to do, but the episode still cost the sector a lot of value. Has it changed how the firm thinks about educating the wealth channel — or about how much growth should come from semi-liquid products?"

WHY IT LANDS

It concedes their best argument first, then asks the genuinely hard question. It shows you understand the product mechanics rather than the headline. Almost nobody at a student event will ask this.

"BXPE went from launch to \$25bn of NAV in ten quarters, but BCRED had a very different year. From where you sit, what actually determines whether one of these vehicles gets adopted by advisers?"

WHY IT LANDS

It asks about their craft — distribution — rather than about investment performance, and it treats adviser behaviour as the interesting variable, which is how people in that job actually think.

"How do the European product set and regulatory regime differ from the US one? I noticed BXPE is offered to non-US investors through a different structure."

WHY IT LANDS

Specific, local, and shows you looked past the American headlines. A London private wealth person deals with exactly this every day.

"What separates the analysts on your team who become great client people from the ones who stay merely competent?"

WHY IT LANDS

It is a question about their team rather than about you, so it gets a real answer. Far better than "what do you look for?"

IF YOU MEET SOMEONE SENIOR — A MANAGING DIRECTOR OR ABOVE

"Credit and Insurance is now the largest segment by assets but contributes a much smaller share of earnings because fee rates are lower. Is the bet that volume and durability more than compensate for that?"

WHY IT LANDS

It demonstrates you can read a segment disclosure, and it asks about strategy rather than trivia. This is a question a junior analyst at a competitor would ask.

"The data centre platform has gone from \$130bn to \$185bn in six months. How does the firm think about the difference between owning powered land, which seems genuinely scarce, and financing compute, where the technology risk is higher?"

WHY IT LANDS

It shows you understand there are distinct layers to the AI trade and that Blackstone occupies them differently. It invites a genuinely interesting answer.

"The firm's culture is described as one where the best idea wins regardless of hierarchy. How does that actually work in an investment committee when a deal already has momentum behind it?"

WHY IT LANDS

It takes the firm's own stated culture seriously enough to test it. Senior people generally enjoy this question because they have a real story about it.

IF YOU MEET AN ANALYST OR ASSOCIATE — SOMEONE ONE TO FOUR YEARS IN

"What is something about the job that you did not expect before you started?"

WHY IT LANDS

Warm, easy to answer honestly, and it usually produces the most useful information of the evening.

"How much of your week is actually with clients versus internal — and did that ratio change as you got more senior?"	
WHY IT LANDS	Concrete and answerable. It also signals that you have thought about what the work is rather than what it sounds like.
"Which team here would you have joined if you had not joined yours?"	
WHY IT LANDS	It gets you a candid map of the firm's internal reputation in one answer.
IF YOU MEET SOMEONE IN REAL ESTATE	
"Private real estate marks have lagged listed REITs this year. Is that a lag that closes, or does it say something about how the two markets are pricing the same assets?"	
WHY IT LANDS	It is <i>the</i> live debate in the asset class, phrased neutrally rather than as an accusation.
"Indurent looks like the platform-building playbook run in the UK from scratch. Is a London listing genuinely attractive right now, or is a sale the more likely route?"	
WHY IT LANDS	UK-specific, current, and about their actual work rather than about Blackstone in the abstract.

The last mile

11.3 What not to do

- **Do not call it BlackRock.** Different firm. If you slip, correct it cleanly and move on without making it a thing.
- **Do not ask "so what do you do?" and then not listen.** The most common failure at these events is treating people as a queue.
- **Do not ask about compensation, hours, or how many people get offers.** Not tonight.
- **Do not open with the share price** or with a criticism. Both are fine later in a good conversation; neither is a first sentence.
- **Do not claim to have read something you have not.** "I read the Q2 results" is only worth saying if you can name a number from them.
- **Do not perform.** Reciting AUM figures unprompted reads as anxiety. Deploy detail only when it answers something.
- **Do not monopolise a senior person** while four other students wait. Take five good minutes and leave well.
- **Do not ask them to refer you.** Ask for their view, not their sponsorship. The referral, if it comes, comes later.
- **Do not forget the SEO context.** Blackstone is on the steering group of SEO London's Alternative Investment Programme and sponsors its real estate programme. This is a long-standing partnership, not a one-off — worth acknowledging warmly and briefly.

11.4 Your opening, and your close

THE OPENING — ROUGHLY 25 SECONDS

Name, what you study, one specific reason you are interested that is *not* "I want to work in finance." Then a question. The specific reason is the whole game: it should be something only you would say.

A worked example of the shape, in your own words: *"I'm Janak — I study [X] at [Y]. What pulled me toward Blackstone rather than banking is the client side: the fact that raising and keeping capital has become as strategic as investing it, especially with perpetual vehicles. I'd love to hear how that looks from where you sit."*

THE CLOSE — ROUGHLY 15 SECONDS

Thank them by name. Say one specific thing you took from the conversation — this is what makes you memorable, because almost nobody does it. Ask if you may follow up on LinkedIn or by email.

Then actually do it, within 24 hours, referencing that same specific thing. A follow-up that says "thank you for your time" is forgettable. One that says "your point about advisers needing to understand the gate before they buy has stuck with me" is not.

11.5 Jargon decoder — the one-page version

IF THEY SAY...	THEY MEAN
FRE	Fee-Related Earnings — recurring profit from management fees. \$1.8bn in Q2. The number the stock market pays for
DE	Distributable Earnings — cash available to shareholders. \$2.0bn in Q2
Dry powder	Committed but unspent capital. \$228bn. Future fee revenue, not idle cash
Perpetual capital	Vehicles with no end date. \$555.6bn
Carry / carried interest	The 20% profit share, paid only after investors get their capital back plus a preferred return
The hurdle / pref	The return (usually 8%) investors must receive before carry is earned
Re-up	An existing investor committing to the next fund in a series. The real measure of client satisfaction
A gate	The cap on redemptions from a semi-liquid fund, usually 5% of NAV per quarter
Deployment / realisations	Money going into investments / money coming back out of them
Core+ vs opportunistic	Stabilised, income-producing property held indefinitely vs. broken property fixed and sold in 3–7 years

IF THEY SAY...	THEY MEAN
SMA	Separately Managed Account — a bespoke mandate for one large client, the standard structure in insurance
BDC	Business Development Company — the US structure BCRED uses to lend to mid-sized companies
Secondaries	Buying existing fund stakes from investors who want liquidity early. Blackstone's Strategic Partners is a leader
GP-led	A secondaries deal initiated by the fund manager rather than by an investor — often to hold a good asset longer
Co-invest	An investor putting extra money directly into a single deal alongside the fund, usually at reduced or no fees
Hyperscaler	The very large cloud buyers — the tenants in Blackstone's data centres
Neocloud	A newer provider renting out AI compute capacity. Blackstone is building one with Google

FINAL THOUGHT

You will not be assessed tonight on how much you know about Blackstone. You will be assessed — informally, and mostly unconsciously — on whether you are someone people would want in a room with a client. Preparation buys you the confidence to stop performing and start listening. That is what all of this is actually for.

Sources and basis of preparation

Everything in this report is drawn from public sources available on or before 2 September 2026. Figures are as reported and have not been independently verified.

PRIMARY — BLACKSTONE DISCLOSURE

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BREIT and BCRED SEC filings and fund websites; BXPE / BXPEF fund documentation

Corebridge Financial SEC filings (Blackstone-managed asset disclosures; Equitable merger announcement)

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PRESS AND MARKET REPORTING

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CNBC — "Investors poured billions into private credit. Now many want their money back" (March 2026)

CNBC — Joan Solotar on separating private credit "signal from the noise" (April 2026)

CNBC — "Private credit's 'zero-loss fantasy' is coming to an end" (March 2026)

Fortune — "The \$265 billion private credit meltdown" (March 2026)

With Intelligence — BDC portfolios, redemptions and credit stress; private equity fundraising misses

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Bloomberg — Champions Group; Knowledge Realty Trust stake sale; \$3bn collateralised fund obligation

Bisnow — Big Yellow Group; Indurent exit; Blackstone data centre public company

CoStar — BREP X fundraise; Blackstone UK last-mile logistics

Reuters / Investing.com — Blackstone retirement unit; Vanguard and Wellington partnership

Alternative Credit Investor — Blackstone and Empower 401(k) partnership

SDxCentral and Yahoo Finance — Broadcom AI XPV financing platform

CRE Analyst — BREP fund IRR resets; Jon Gray on the real estate recovery

Morningstar — alternative manager share performance; peer AUM and credit concentration comparisons

Private Equity Stakeholder Project — LivCor / RealPage DOJ settlement and multi-family housing tracker

Wealth Management, Yahoo Finance, Trading Economics, MacroTrends — share price, market capitalisation, headcount

SEO London and Permira — Alternative Investment Programme steering group and Step into Real Estate sponsors

Wikipedia and company histories — founding, IPO and corporate milestones (cross-checked against primary filings where possible)

REMINDER

This document contains no confidential or non-public information. Several figures — notably institutional AUM, market capitalisation, and indicative target returns by real estate strategy — are derived or approximate and are flagged as such where they appear. Deal statuses reported as "under consideration" may not complete. Nothing here is investment advice.